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Sociolinguistic Dimensions of Digital Discourse: A Comparative Study of Male
and Female Responses on Crimes Against Women

A Graduation Research in Linguistics

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Outline

Thesis Statement:

This research paper applies Lakoff's Deficit Model (1975), Tannen's Difference Model (1990), and Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model (1975) to male and female comments on four social media posts published on X (Twitter) and Instagram addressing crimes, namely gender-based violence against women. It also aims at investigating the syntactic and morphological differences in language use that characterize male and female discourse concerning this topic by applying morphological and syntactic features to the same data.

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1. Introduction

1.1. Scope of the Research

Social media has fundamentally transformed the landscape of modern communication, serving not merely as a tool for connectivity but as a primary context for the construction of public discourse and identity. In sociolinguistics, the study of online communication has become increasingly important, particularly in examining how individuals use language to express opinions on sensitive social issues. One such critical subject is crime, more specifically, gender-based violence against women, which frequently generates intense debate and revealing commentary across digital platforms.

Analyzing the linguistic choices made by users in this context is therefore essential to understanding how gender identity shapes communication patterns in the digital age. While previous sociolinguistic studies have provided valuable insights into gendered language using established frameworks, a notable gap remains, as few studies have examined the specific syntactic and morphological features of online comments on gender-based violence on social media platforms such as X (Twitter) and Instagram.

Accordingly, this research paper applies Lakoff's Deficit Model (1975), Tannen's Difference Model (1990), and Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model (1975) to male and female comments on four social media posts published on X (Twitter) and Instagram addressing crimes, namely gender-based violence against women. It also aims at investigating the syntactic and morphological differences in language use that characterize male and female discourse concerning this topic by applying morphological and syntactic features to the same data.

1.2. Objectives of the Research

This study primarily aims at identifying the specific syntactic and morphological differences in male and female comments on social media posts addressing gender-based violence against women. Additionally, it seeks to examine whether these identified features align with or deviate from the gendered speech norms proposed by Lakoff's Deficit Model (1975), Tannen's Difference Model (1990), and Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model (1975). Finally, this research seeks to assess the validity of applying these traditional sociolinguistic frameworks, originally developed for spoken interaction, to the written context of contemporary digital discourse.

1.3. Research Questions

This paper aims to find answers to the following research questions:

1. What specific syntactic and morphological differences characterize the language used by men versus women when commenting on gender-based violence on X (Twitter) and Instagram?
2. To what extent do these identified linguistic patterns align with or deviate from the gendered speech norms proposed by Lakoff's Deficit Model, Tannen's Difference Model, and Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model?
3. How does the written context of modern digital discourse impact the validity of applying these traditional sociolinguistic frameworks, which were originally developed for spoken interaction?

1.4. Methodology

This research adopts a triangulation mixed-methods approach, drawing on Creswell's (2009) view of triangulation as the intentional integration of

qualitative and quantitative procedures to enhance credibility, depth, and overall validity. Guided by Lim's (2023) understanding of research paradigms as frameworks that shape how knowledge is generated, the qualitative component focuses on meaning, context, and non-numerical linguistic patterns. In parallel, the quantitative component follows Oranga and Matere's (2024) definition of quantitative research as a systematic, numerical investigation used to identify measurable patterns and relationships. Procedurally, the research unfolds in several steps: First, comments addressing gender-based violence are extracted from posts on X (Twitter) and Instagram. The researcher then analyzes syntactic and morphological features while simultaneously interpreting their communicative intent. Finally, the results are cross-referenced with the models of Lakoff (1975), Tannen (1990), and Zimmerman and West (1975) to present a comprehensive conclusion on gendered digital discourse.

1.5. Sources of Data

The data in this research is drawn from verified and official accounts on X (Twitter) and Instagram. The selected posts were published by public figures and reputable newspapers rather than personal or anonymous accounts, ensuring the credibility and authenticity of the discourse examined. The dataset consists of thirty comments extracted from four posts, one from X (Twitter) and three from Instagram. These comments are divided into two equal groups: fifteen written by males and fifteen written by females. This equal distribution was intentionally maintained to support a fair comparative analysis. The chosen sources are widely circulated, and their high visibility generates substantial engagement, providing a rich and representative dataset of authentic public opinion suitable for sociolinguistic analysis.

1.6. Context of Data

The chosen sets of comments revolve around posts that have been published during the past two years about certain events, namely gender-based violence against women. These specific cases were chosen because they sparked widespread controversy regarding the failure of legal systems to protect women, providing a polarized environment essential for observing gendered linguistic differences. Both male and female users have actively engaged in the discourse surrounding these tragic incidents, underscoring that this subject remains one of the most critical social issues of the contemporary era. Extending beyond the specific nations involved, it has established itself as a global phenomenon. Furthermore, this widespread concern has sustained extensive public debate for many years, impacting the international community.

1.7. Review of Literature

A study by Ibkar (2017) investigates gendered linguistic patterns by applying Lakoff's Deficit Model (1975) to written speech within social media. Utilizing a participatory-observation method, the researcher evaluates how digital platforms influence traditional female speech characteristics. The findings reveal that traditional linguistic boundaries are blurred in online environments, leading to the conclusion that Lakoff's parameters are no longer entirely applicable to digital discourse.

Ejiaso (2024) examines the representation of linguistic violence against women within Nigerian ritual killing discourse on Facebook and Twitter. Utilizing Fairclough's Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA), the study evaluates textual data to uncover underlying power structures in social media spaces. The findings indicate that discursive representations often systematically blame

victims while excusing male perpetrators, thereby sustaining patriarchal subjugation.

A study by Farooq, Khan, and Alphonse (2024) investigates gendered language on Facebook by applying Brown and Levinson's (1987) Politeness Theory to male and female comments. Using a mixed-methods approach, the researchers conducted a quantitative analysis of frequency alongside a qualitative evaluation of politeness strategies. The results verified Lakoff's (1975) original argument, revealing that females utilize a higher frequency of positive politeness strategies than males.

Sari, Gunawan, and Sudana (2020) analyze language variations in Instagram captions by applying Lakoff's (1975) theory of gender features. Through a descriptive qualitative method and non-participatory observation, the researchers identified seven specific linguistic features, including lexical hedges, tag questions, and intensifiers. The study concludes that while digital expression allows for some overlap, distinct gendered differences persist in the realization of Instagram captions.

Hocine (2018) analyzes gendered linguistic differences within criminal discourse by examining first-person interviews from reality television and documentaries. Applying Tannen's (1990) Difference/ Cultural Approach and Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model, the researcher investigates the use of hedging, negation, and evaluative adjectives among male and female criminals. The results indicate that female criminal discourse often functions as a rebellion against traditional gender stereotypes, as women in this context reject the victim role in favor of assertive linguistic identities.

To the best of the researcher's knowledge, no previous study has applied the same theoretical framework to the same type of data under investigation. This research applies Lakoff's Deficit Model (1975), Tannen's Difference Model

(1990), and Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model (1975) to the systematic analysis of male and female comments addressing gender-based violence against women. Drawing on comments extracted from X (Twitter) and Instagram, this study foregrounds gender-based differences between two sets of data under analysis regarding this topic syntactically and morphologically.

2. Theoretical Framework

2.1 Morphological Features

Morphology is the branch of linguistics dedicated to the systematic study of the internal structure of words and the principles governing their formation. It focuses on the identification and analysis of morphemes, which are the smallest units of language that carry distinct meaning or grammatical function. By investigating the relationship between a word's form and its meaning, this discipline reveals how a language's lexicon is organized and how new words are created. It also explores how these units interact to signal grammatical relationships, serving as a bridge between individual sounds and complex sentence structures.

2.1.1 Compounding

Compounding is the merging of two or more words to form a new word with a single meaning and function. According to Bauer (1983), compounding, also referred to as composition, is “the process of putting two words together to form a third” (p. 11). Through this process, separate lexical items are combined to express a unified concept and function as a single lexical item in the language. In English, compounds may be written as a single word, as hyphenated forms, or as separate words. Bauer (1983) illustrates this process with examples such as *oil-paper*, *paperclip*, *paper aeroplane*, *wastepaper*, and *wastepaper basket*,

demonstrating that orthographic form does not affect the lexical unity of compound words (pp. 28–29).

2.1.2 Invention

Invention, also known as word manufacture, is the creation of a completely new word that is not formed from existing words or morphemes and does not follow regular morphological patterns. Bauer (1983) states that invention involves the introduction of lexical items that are not derived through established word-formation processes such as compounding or derivation (1983, p. 141). Through this process, entirely new lexical items enter the language and function as independent units within the lexicon. In English, words formed by invention are often made to name new objects, products, or concepts, such as *grok* (p. 239).

2.1.3 Tense Marking

Tense is an inflectional category of verbs that manifests in English primarily through the contrast between present and past. Carstairs-McCarthy (2002) states that tense marking creates grammatically conditioned variants of a single lexeme, for example, *perform*, *performs*, and *performed*. These forms are often dictated by the grammatical context, such as the "sequence of tenses" rule, where a past-tense verb of saying triggers a past-tense form in the reported clause (pp. 28 - 38).

2.1.4 Clipping

Bauer (1983) defines clipping as a morphological process in which a word, simple or complex, is shortened while retaining its original meaning and grammatical category. It often reflects a shift in stylistic level, signaling familiarity. Clipping is unpredictable, with no fixed rules for syllable retention, stress, or structure. Most commonly, the initial part of a word is kept. To exemplify, *deli* from *delicatessen*, *mike* from *microphone*, sometimes the final

part *Cong* from *Viet Cong*, and rarely the middle, like *jams* from *pyjamas*. Clipped forms can also appear in compounds, forming “clipped compounds” like *sitcom* from *situation comedy* or *sci-fi* from *science fiction* (p. 233).

2.1.5 Blending

A blend, also known as a “*portmanteau word*,” is defined by Bauer (1983) as a novel lexeme constructed from the merged parts of two or more existing words, and usually consists of combining the start of one word with the ending of another, like in *motel* (*motor* + *hotel*), and *frenemy* (*friend* + *enemy*).

2.1.6 Conversion

Bauer (1983) explains conversion as a morphological process in which a word changes its grammatical or syntactic category without any change to its form, effectively making a new word from an existing one. The derived form remains identical in pronunciation and spelling to its base. For example, the noun *napalm* can become the verb “*to napalm*,” and “*bottle*” can become “*to bottle*” (p. 32). Conversion allows words to occupy new syntactic roles while often gaining more complex or specialized meanings. It is a highly productive process in English, enabling flexible word-formation without overt changes to the original word.

2.1.7 Derivation

Derivation is a word-formation process in which new words are formed by adding affixes to an existing base. Bauer (1983) elaborates that derivational affixes create new lexemes, unlike inflectional affixes, which only produce different grammatical forms of the same word (pp. 18–19). Derivation may change the meaning and sometimes the word class of the base, resulting in a new independent word in the vocabulary. He illustrates derivation with examples such as *teach* → *teacher*, *kind* → *kindness*, and *modern* → *modernize* (pp. 18–22).

2.1.8 Acronymy

Acronyms are a special type of blend in which each component of a phrase is usually reduced to its initial letter or sound. According to Carstairs-McCarthy (2002), a true acronym is pronounced as a regular word, following standard reading rules. Examples include NATO (*North Atlantic Treaty Organisation*), and RAM (*random access memory*). He distinguishes acronyms from abbreviations or initialisms, where the letters are pronounced individually, such as USA, RP, or BBC. Some words, like sonar (*sound navigation and ranging*), occupy an intermediate space between blends and true acronyms (p. 65).

2.1.9 Back-formation

Back-formation is a morphological process in which a new word is created by removing a suffix, or a perceived suffix, from an existing word. According to Bauer (1983), this process is motivated by analogy with familiar word pairs. As a result, back-formation often produces a word belonging to a different grammatical category from its base, such as the verb *laze* formed from the adjective *lazy* (p. 64).

2.2 Syntactic Features

Syntax is the branch of linguistics dedicated to the systematic study of the internal structure of sentences and the principles governing the arrangement of words into phrases and clauses. It focuses on the identification and analysis of the rules that determine how constituents are combined to form well-formed, grammatical expressions within a language. By analyzing hierarchical relationships between word categories like nouns and verbs, syntax demonstrates how a finite set of rules generates an infinite variety of sentences. It examines how these structures signal grammatical dependencies, bridging the gap between individual word meanings and the communication of complex ideas.

2.2.1 Epistemic Modality

According to Palmer (2001), epistemic modality concerns the speaker's assessment of a proposition's truth, reflecting degrees of knowledge or belief rather than obligation. This "propositional modality" operates along a continuum, ranging from certainty to probability and possibility, marking the speaker's varying levels of commitment to the statement (pp. 7–8, 24–25).

At the high end of this scale, epistemic certainty signals strong confidence or deductive necessity. This is typically encoded through modal operators such as *must*, as in "John *must* be in his office," and *will*, or reinforced by modal adjuncts like *certainly* and *definitely*. These markers indicate that the speaker considers the proposition highly reliable based on the available evidence (Palmer, 2001, pp. 24–25, 30).

Epistemic probability represents an intermediate commitment, where a proposition is deemed likely but not guaranteed. This level is expressed through modals like *should* and *ought to*, adjuncts such as *probably*, or lexical verbs like *think* and *suppose*. Finally, at the low end of the scale, epistemic possibility signals a merely speculative or potential truth. This is marked by modals such as *may*, *might*, and *can*, or adjuncts like *perhaps* and *possibly*, highlighting the provisional status of the speaker's judgment (Palmer, 2001, pp. 9, 24–30).

2.2.2 Deontic Modality

Deontic modality refers to the expression of obligation, advisability, or permission, indicating whether an action is required, recommended, or allowed within a normative framework such as law, convention, or social expectation. Palmer treats deontic modality as a type of event modality, since it concerns actions that are potential rather than actual, and classifies it along a continuum of necessity, advisability, and possibility (Palmer, 2001, p. 9).

Deontic necessity conveys a strong obligation and is commonly encoded through modals such as *must*, as in “John *must* leave,” or *have to*, which indicate that the subject is bound to perform the action. It can also be expressed in clauses with adjectives such as *necessary*, *compulsory*, *obligatory*, or *urgent*, or through past participle constructions such as *required* or *obliged*, all of which encode externally imposed duties (Palmer, 2001, pp. 9, 10, 71, 141).

Deontic advisability marks a moderate degree of obligation, expressing recommendation rather than strict requirement. This is typically realized through modal operators *should* and *ought to* (He *should/ ought to* come), adjectival clauses with *advisable*, or past participles such as *supposed*, *advised*, and *suggested*, which all indicate that an action is desirable or recommended but not strictly necessary (Palmer, 2001, pp. 70–73, 125).

Deontic possibility represents the lowest degree of obligation and corresponds to permission. It is expressed through modals such as *may* and *can*, and through adjectival clauses with *possible*, indicating that the subject is allowed to perform the action without being required to do so (Palmer, 2001, pp. 9, 10, 71).

2.2.3 Types of Mood

According to Palmer (2001), moods in English indicate the speaker’s stance toward the proposition and are distinguished by their communicative functions. The indicative mood serves as the unmarked or “fact” mood, employed for statements of fact and assertions in which the speaker affirms the truth of the proposition, as in “*Mary is at home*” or “*It rained*” (Palmer, 2001, pp. 107, 177, 218).

The imperative mood, in contrast, is a performative form used to issue commands, requests, or instructions, reflecting event modality since it aims to

prompt action by the addressee; typical examples include “*Come in!*”, “*Go!*”, or “*Take your book*” (Palmer, 2001, pp. 80, 202, 269).

The subjunctive mood generally occurs in subordinate clauses to indicate propositions that are presupposed rather than asserted as factual, often conveying the speaker’s attitude such as doubt, desire, or necessity, for instance, “*I suggest that he stay*”, “*I am glad that you know the truth*” (Palmer, 2001, pp. 107, 111, 201).

The interrogative mood functions to elicit information or confirmation and is classified as non-assertive because the speaker does not commit to the proposition’s truth; examples include “*Are you a teacher?*”, “*What did you eat?*”, or “*Is John in his office?*” (Palmer, 2001, pp. 52, 171, 182–183).

Finally, the conditional mood expresses hypothetical situations that depend on certain conditions, often marked in English by modal past forms such as *would*, as illustrated in “*If John came, Bill would leave*”, “*If you did this, you would be wrong*”, or “*If he had a boat, he would go to Rome*” (Palmer, 2001, pp. 184, 203, 221).

2.2.4 Finite and Non-Finite Clauses

Clauses in English are classified as finite or non-finite depending on whether the verb is marked for tense and agreement. According to Brinton (2000), a finite clause has a verb marked for tense that often agrees with its subject, allowing it to function as an independent sentence. For example, in “*She writes every day*” and “*She wrote yesterday*,” the verbs *writes* and *wrote* are finite. Finite clauses can also appear as subordinate clauses introduced by complementizers like *that*, *if*, or *because*, as in “*I know that she writes every day*” (pp. 216–238).

A non-finite clause, by contrast, has a verb not marked for tense or agreement. Non-finite verbs appear in the infinitive (*to write*), -ing participle

(*writing*), or -ed participle (*written*) forms. Non-finite clauses cannot stand alone and depend on a main clause for temporal reference. For example, “*To write well requires practice*” (*infinitive*), “*Writing every day improves your skills*” (*-ing participle*), and “*Written in haste, the letter contained mistakes*” (*-ed participle*) illustrate their functions. The key distinction is that finite clauses carry tense and agreement, while non-finite clauses do not, affecting their syntactic role (pp. 216–246).

2.2.5. Agent and Patient Roles

Within the framework of sentence semantics, thematic roles represent the functional relationships between a predicate and its nominal arguments. Two of the most central roles in this system are the Agent and the Patient.

The Agent refers to the participant who deliberately initiates or carries out the action. This role typically involves intention and control over the event. In other words, the Agent is the entity responsible for bringing about the action described by the verb. For example, in “*The logger felled the tree,*” the logger is the Agent since he actively carried out the felling of the tree (Brinton, 2000, pp. 117, 267, 269).

The Patient refers to the person or object that is affected by an action, and the entity that experiences physical change. The Patient is also usually realized as the direct object in active sentences or moves to the subject position in a passive construction. For example, in “*I baked the chicken,*” the chicken is what undergoes a change due to the baking process, thus referred to as the Patient (Brinton, 2000, pp. 268, 270).

2.2.6 Copula and Non-Copula Constructions

Brinton (2000) explains that copular constructions are clauses in which the verb *be* and other similar linking verbs such as *seem* and *become*, function to

connect the subject with a subject complement. In these structures, the verb does not assign itself roles such as Agent and Patient; instead, it develops a relationship of identification. To exemplify this, in “*The sky is blue*,” the verb *is* simply links the subject *sky* to the adjective *blue*.

By contrast, non-copular constructions contain lexical verbs that carry independent meaning and typically denote actions, events, or processes. Such verbs take objects and assign semantic roles to participants. For instance, in “*Maria opened the door*,” the verb *opened* expresses the action done by the subject. He also states that lexical verbs in English require do-support when forming negatives and questions. To exemplify, “*He wins two medals*,” becomes “*He does not win two medals*” and “*Does he win two medals?*”

2.2.7 Sentence Ambiguity due to syntactic features

Brinton (2000) discusses how syntactic features can give rise to ambiguity when a sentence allows more than one grammatical interpretation. This structural or syntactic ambiguity does not arise from the meaning of individual words, but from the way the constituents are grouped and built within the clause. Since English relies heavily on word order and phrase structures, different internal groupings can lead to the production of different interpretations. For instance, the sentence “*The shooting of the hunters occurred at dawn*” can be interpreted in different ways: it could mean that the hunters were the victims who were shot by someone else, or it could mean that the hunters were the actors who began firing their own weapons at dawn (pp. 164, 260). Additionally, in a modern context, “shooting” might not involve weapons at all; it could simply mean a photographer was taking pictures of the group as the sun rose.

2.2.8 Main and Subordinate Clauses

The main clause, alternatively termed a superordinate clause, serves as the primary structural foundation of a complex sentence. It is characterized by its

syntactic independence, meaning it possesses the grammatical capacity to stand alone as a complete sentence. This unit consists of two essential constituents: the subject (the noun phrase or NP) and the predicate (the verb phrase or VP). Because it contains both a topic and a comment, it expresses a complete proposition without requiring external support (Brinton, 2000, p. 168). For example, the sentence *The scientist observed the reaction*, functions as a main clause as it contains both a subject, *The scientist*, who is the actor/ topic being discussed, and a predicate, *observed the reaction*, which provides the action. Both work together to express a complete, independent thought.

Subordinate clauses, also known as dependent, embedded, or lower clauses, are grammatically reliant on a main clause through a process of embedding (Brinton, 2000, p. 214). These units are categorized into three primary types based on their syntactic function: noun clauses (nominal clauses), which perform the roles of subjects or objects; adjective clauses (relative clauses), which follow and modify a head noun to identify or describe a referent; and adverbial clauses, which provide the contextual or logical framework for the sentence (pp. 217–222). By functioning as adjuncts or complements, these clauses establish essential context such as time, reason, or condition. For instance, in the sentence *The scientist observed the reaction because the results were unexpected*, the adverbial subordinate clause *because the results were unexpected* expresses reason; although it contains both a subject and a predicate, it is a finite clause that cannot stand independently, as it serves only to provide the reason for the main action.

2.2.9 Case, Gender and Mood

Brinton (2000) presents case, gender, and mood as grammatical categories that signal important relationships in clause structures. Case marks the syntactic function of noun phrases, gender reflects distinctions associated mainly with

pronoun reference, and mood expresses the speaker's attitude toward the proposition of the clause.

Case refers to the grammatical marking that shows the role of a noun phrase in a sentence, especially its relationship to the verb or to other noun phrases. English distinguishes three main cases: nominative, objective, and possessive (genitive). The nominative case marks the subject of the clause, expressing the doer of the action. The objective case marks the object of the clause, which is the receiver of an action. Finally, the possessive (genitive) case shows ownership and related associations.

In contrast to pronouns, most English nouns do not show separate morphological forms for the nominative and objective case. Instead, grammatical function is primarily determined by word order in the clause. For example, in the sentence "*The ship struck the dock*," the noun phrase preceding the verb functions as the subject (nominative), while the noun phrase following the verb functions as the object (objective), even though both appear in the same base form (Brinton, 2000, p. 108). The genitive case of nouns, however, is marked either by the inflectional ending 's, for example "*The teacher's book*," or by an apostrophe following a plural noun like in "*The students' classroom*." Moreover, the possessive does not solely indicate ownership; it may also express relationships such as origin or measure, as in "*Shakespeare's plays*" or "*an hour's time*" (pp. 108–109). Although English case marking is relatively limited, these distinctions remain essential for identifying grammatical relations within sentences.

Brinton (2000) explains that Modern English follows a system of natural gender, meaning that gender distinctions are based primarily on real-world sex rather than on grammatical classification (pp. 105–106). English recognizes four gender categories: masculine, feminine, common (dual), and neuter. Masculine and feminine genders apply to male and female human referents, respectively,

while the neuter gender applies mainly to inanimate entities. Common gender refers to nouns that may denote either males or females, depending on context.

For instance, masculine gender is denoted by the pronoun *he* and nouns such as *father*, *grandfather*, *nephew*, and *emperor*. Feminine gender refers to female persons and is signified by the pronoun *she*. Some examples of feminine nouns are *mother*, *aunt*, *bride*, *actress*, and *princess*. Neuter gender refers to things, objects, or ideas that do not have biological sex and takes the pronoun *it*. Some examples of neuter nouns are *book*, *computer*, *desk*, and *rock*. Finally, common gender nouns can refer to either males or females depending on the context, and the pronouns used (*he* or *she*) depend on the person being referred to.

According to Palmer (2001), mood in English expresses the speaker's attitude toward a proposition through different communicative functions. The indicative mood is the unmarked form used for factual statements and assertions, as in "*Mary is at home*" or "*It rained*" (pp. 107, 177, 218). The imperative mood is performative and action-oriented, used for commands or requests such as "*Come in!*," "*Go!*," and "*Take your book.*" The subjunctive mood typically appears in subordinate clauses to express non-factual or presupposed meanings, including doubt, desire, or necessity, as in "*I suggest that he stay*," and "*I am glad that you know the truth*" (pp. 107, 111, 201). The interrogative mood is non-assertive and serves to seek information or confirmation, as in "*Are you a teacher?*" "*What did you eat?*", and "*Is John in his office?*" (pp. 52, 171, 182-183). Finally, the conditional mood expresses hypothetical situations dependent on certain conditions, commonly marked by modal past forms such as *would*, as in "*If John came, Bill would leave*," or "*If he had a boat, he would go to Rome*" (pp. 184, 203, 221).

2.2.10 Aspect, Tense, and Voice

Aspect, tense, and voice are fundamental grammatical categories in English that describe how actions are expressed in relation to time, duration, and the relationship between the subject and the verb.

According to Brinton (2000), aspect is a grammatical category that shows how a speaker views an event as complete or ongoing. In English, it is expressed through simple, progressive, perfect, and perfect progressive forms. The simple past conveys a perfective aspect, presenting an event as complete, like in “*Yesterday, I drove to town, ran errands, and visited friends*” (p. 114). The progressive expresses imperfective meaning, showing an ongoing action, and is formed with *be* + *-ing*, as exemplified in “*She is swimming*” or “*He is bouncing the ball*” (p. 114); it rarely occurs with stative verbs, as in “*I am liking chocolate.*” The perfect, formed with *have* + *past participle*, highlights present relevance of a past event and can be continuative “*I have lived here since childhood*”, resultative “*I have lost my keys*”, or experiential “*I have read that novel*” (p. 114). The perfect progressive combines these meanings, describing actions continuing from the past into the present, e.g., “*I have been reading the novel for the last hour*” (p. 115). Finally, the present participle (*-ing*) is non-finite and central to the progressive (*She is singing*), but it can also function as a noun (*Swimming is good exercise*) or modifier (*The girl smiling sweetly...*) (p. 115).

As explained by Brinton (2000), tense is a grammatical category that locates an event in time relative to the moment of speaking. English distinguishes three main tenses: past, present, and future.

The present tense does not always indicate actions occurring at the exact moment of speaking. For actions happening now, English uses the present progressive, as in “*I am reading at this moment*” (Brinton, 2000, p.112). The simple present is used for habits, states, general truths, timeless facts, scheduled

future events, and storytelling. Examples include “*I walk to work every day,*” “*Tigers are ferocious,*” and “*The sun sets in the west*” (p.112).

The past tense generally indicates actions or states that occurred before the present. It is also the usual tense for narration: “*Haydn composed the symphony in 1758*” (p.113). The past can express past habits, as in “*I used to drive to work,*” politeness, as in “*I was hoping you could help,*” or hypothetical situations, as in “*If you studied more, you would do better*” (p.113).

The future tense is expressed periphrastically in English rather than by inflection. Common forms include will/shall + infinitive like in “*I will help you tomorrow*”, the simple present for scheduled events, “*The train leaves at 6:00,*” the present progressive for planned events, “*We’re having guests for dinner*”, and be going to / be about to + infinitive “*The child is going to be sick*” (Brinton, 2000, p.113). Future forms may also combine with the progressive to show actions in progress relative to another future point: “*It will be raining tomorrow*” (p.113).

According to Brinton (2000), voice is a grammatical category that shows whether the subject of a sentence performs the action or is affected by it. In English, there are two main voices: active and passive.

The active voice occurs when the subject performs the action of the verb. It is expressed with the simple forms of the verb, as in “*The committee wrote the report*” (Brinton, 2000, p.116).

The passive voice occurs when the subject is affected by the action or acted upon. It is formed periphrastically with be + past participle, as in “*The report was written by the committee,*” or with get + past participle, as in “*The criminal got caught by the police*” (Brinton, 2000, p.116). The be-passive emphasizes the resultant state, while the get-passive emphasizes the action that caused it. In the

passive, the agent (the logical subject) can be included in a by-phrase, as in the examples above, or omitted altogether: "*The report was written*" (p.116).

3. Sociolinguistic Models

3.1 Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model

Robin Lakoff's 1975 work, *Language and Woman's Place*, serves as the foundation for the "deficit model" in sociolinguistics, arguing that women are socialized to use a specific set of linguistic features that characterize their speech as hesitant, over-polite, and ultimately subordinate to the male standard. In this deficit-based model, women's language is described as reflecting social powerlessness, manifested through a cluster of recurrent linguistic features.

Firstly, backchanneling, also known as minimal responses (e.g., *mm*, *yeah*, *right*), is interpreted as excessive listener support, signaling attentiveness but also conversational subordination, as women are positioned as facilitators rather than controllers of discourse (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, pp. 87-88).

Similarly, hedging devices such as *sort of*, *maybe*, and *I think* are said to weaken the force of assertions, indicating uncertainty and lack of authority rather than strategic politeness. (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, p. 88). Intensifiers like *so* and *very* are treated ambivalently: although they amplify meaning, Lakoff argues that their overuse substitutes emotional emphasis for factual authority, reinforcing stereotypes of emotional rather than rational speech (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, pp. 12-13, 108).

Lakoff also highlights apologies and over-apologizing as core features of women's language, claiming that women apologize more frequently and in contexts where no offense has occurred, thereby pre-emptively accepting blame and reinforcing lower social status (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, pp. 104-105).

This extends to tag questions (e.g., *It's nice, isn't it?*), which Lakoff argues function not as genuine requests for information but as markers of tentativeness, positioning the speaker as seeking approval rather than asserting knowledge (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, p. 90). Likewise, modal verbs such as *might*, *could*, and *would* are interpreted as further softening devices that reduce the speaker's authority.

Another defining feature in Lakoff's framework is the use of "empty" adjectives (e.g., *lovely*, *adorable*, *divine*), which are said to convey affective evaluation without precise informational content. Lakoff argues that such adjectives are socially restricted to women and index triviality and emotionality rather than seriousness. Closely related is her notion of "talking in italics," referring to exaggerated stress, intonation, or prosodic emphasis, which Lakoff interprets as compensating for a lack of direct power in speech. This prosodic markedness, she argues, further distances women's speech from the unmarked norm of male language (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, pp. 6, 12, 108).

Lakoff also identifies a preference for indirect commands, WH-imperatives (e.g., *Why don't you open the window?*), and polite forms (*please*, mitigated requests), arguing that women avoid direct imperatives to maintain social harmony at the cost of authority (Lakoff, 1975, p. 56)

Euphemisms are similarly framed as evidence of women's linguistic politeness and moral constraint, particularly in relation to taboo topics. Lakoff summarizes her position later by saying 'women don't use offcolor or indelicate expressions; women are the experts at euphemism' (Lakoff, 1975, p. 55). Lakoff further notes women's use of direct quotation as a narrative strategy, suggesting it reflects involvement rather than informational distance. Finally, hypercorrect grammar, strict adherence to standard forms, is interpreted as a response to linguistic insecurity, with women orienting toward prestige norms because their

social status is more vulnerable and more frequently judged (Lakoff, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, pp. 61-63).

Despite its foundational status, this model has been criticized for its negative implication that women's language is intrinsically flawed, suggesting that women must adopt male speech patterns to achieve professional authority (Coates, 2013, p.6).

.2 Deborah Tannen's (1990) Difference Model

Deborah Tannen's 1990 "Difference Model" shifted the sociolinguistic focus from power and deficiency to cultural socialization, proposing that men and women grow up in different "sociolinguistic subcultures" which leads to distinct conversational styles. This framework is best understood through six primary contrasts that define cross-gender communication.

In Tannen's (1990) difference model, status vs. support reflects contrasting communicative orientations. Men are socialized to view interaction through a hierarchical framework in which speakers occupy positions of relative power, leading them to treat conversation as a strategic means of asserting authority and avoiding subordination (p. 13). As a result, talk often functions as a way of managing rank rather than fostering equality. Women, by contrast, tend to interpret social life in relational terms, using conversation as a cooperative tool to exchange support, build connection, and maintain symmetrical relationships based on emotional closeness rather than competition (pp. 13–14).

The distinction between advice and understanding concerns how men and women respond to the sharing of personal problems. Tannen (1990) notes that men are more likely to interpret complaints as requests for solutions and therefore respond with advice, reflecting a problem-solving orientation. However, this approach can create distance by positioning the speaker in a superior role. Women, in contrast, use "troubles talk" primarily to seek empathy and validation

rather than solutions, often responding by sharing similar experiences and acknowledging emotions in order to reinforce rapport and convey solidarity (pp. 34, 36–37).

Regarding information versus feelings, Tannen (1990) distinguishes between "report talk" and "rapport talk." Men generally prioritize report talk, focusing on the exchange of factual information and the display of knowledge, particularly in public settings. Women prioritize rapport talk, which is centered on sharing feelings, personal details, and "small talk" to build and maintain relationships (pp. 36-39).

The distinction between orders and proposals reflects how requests are negotiated. Men are more likely to use direct imperatives, or orders, which align with a focus on hierarchy (Tannen, 1990, pp. 30, 74–76). Women, seeking to avoid the appearance of being bossy, favor "proposals" for joint action. These often take the form of WH-imperatives (e.g., "Why don't we...?") or the use of "let's," framing the request as a collaborative suggestion (pp. 73-76).

In the realm of conflict versus compromise, Tannen (1990) observes that many men regard argument, confrontation, and forms of playful verbal aggression as normal and even pleasurable interactional practices through which status is negotiated and social bonds are formed (pp. 72, 80). Women, by contrast, are more likely to experience conflict as a direct danger to relational stability and therefore seek to minimize or avoid it. As a result, women tend to prioritize compromise and harmon, relying on indirect strategies such as evasion and peacemaking rather than overt disagreement in order to preserve interpersonal relationships (pp. 31, 81).

Finally, the tension between independence and intimacy serves as a fundamental driver of misunderstanding. Men often perceive social relationships as hierarchical, so they prioritize maintaining their independence and avoiding

positions of subordination (Tannen, 1990, pp. 14, 26). In contrast, women tend to view relationships as interconnected networks, placing greater importance on nurturing intimacy and mutual dependence. As a result, men may make decisions on their own to safeguard their autonomy, whereas women usually prefer collaborative decision-making, seeing discussion itself as a reassuring sign of close, interdependent bonds (p. 15).

3.3 Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model (1975)

Zimmerman and West's Dominance Model (1975) conceptualizes women as an oppressed group, interpreting linguistic differences as a reflection of men's dominance and women's subordination (Coates, 2013, p. 6). Scholars using this framework argue that male dominance is actively performed and maintained through everyday language use, such that "doing power" functions as a form of "doing gender" (p. 6). Moreover, the model posits that all participants, both men and women, play a role in sustaining this dominance through discourse.

Zimmerman and West (1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, pp. 113–114) examined how dominance is enacted through turn-taking by recording 31 naturally occurring conversations on a university campus, including same-sex and mixed-sex interactions. They focused on two types of violations: overlaps, where a speaker begins just before the current speaker finishes without cutting them off, and interruptions, where a speaker takes the floor while the other is still talking, directly asserting control.

When comparing same-sex and mixed-sex conversations, Zimmerman and West (1975) found striking differences. In the 20 same-sex conversations, there were only seven interruptions. In contrast, the 11 mixed-sex conversations included 48 interruptions, 46 of which involved a man interrupting a woman. Furthermore, all nine overlaps in these mixed-sex interactions were initiated by men (Zimmerman & West, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, p. 114).

These findings indicate that men rarely interrupt each other, but in mixed-sex conversations, they systematically infringe on women's opportunity to speak, while women initiate no overlaps, showing deference to men's turns. Zimmerman and West concluded that women in contemporary society have restricted rights to speak, with men using interruptions to assert socially sanctioned dominance (Zimmerman & West, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, p. 115). The model also highlights men's use of uncooperative strategies, such as prolonged silences, to exert control. These extended silences often followed interruptions or delayed minimal responses, brief signals like "yeah" or "mhm", which men sometimes postponed, signaling disinterest or lack of understanding, undermining women's contributions and causing the conversation to falter (Zimmerman & West, 1975, as cited in Coates, 2013, p. 123).

4. Application

4.1 Introduction

This section applies the theoretical frameworks outlined in the previous sections to the selected dataset. The analysis draws on thirty comments taken from posts on X (Twitter) and Instagram that discuss cases of gender-based violence against women. The sets of data are evenly divided between male and female users to ensure a balanced comparison. A mixed-method approach is adopted, combining qualitative interpretation with quantitative observation to identify recurring linguistic patterns. The comments are analyzed using Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model and Tannen's (1990) Difference Model to explore gendered communication styles. The research also investigates morphological features and syntactic features within the dataset to identify distinctions between male and female discourse in digital contexts.

4.2 Application of Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model

The application of Lakoff's Deficit Model to the dataset reveals a consistent pattern of linguistic features associated with female discourse. However, male commenters also adopt several of these markers to navigate through the emotional weight of the topic. Lakoff (1975) claims that the deficit features characterize a "powerless" register, which is evidenced here by a tendency toward emotional rapport and caution.

In the female set of data, commenters frequently employ hedges to soften their assertions. These forms signal uncertainty, a lack of authority or a desire to avoid direct confrontation, as seen in instances where speakers double-hedge their advice with phrases like Mira's "*i don't think...*" and Morgan's "*I'm not sure...*". However, hedging is not absent from the male comments; similar mitigators also appear, such as in Jamie's statement "*it will probably keep happening,*" and in Zack's "*I know it might sound insane...*" which helps with softening claims and demonstrating emotional awareness.

Lakoff also identifies the use of empty adjectives that emphasize emotional intensity over informational weight. The female dataset relies heavily on these affective markers, frequently characterizing the violence as "*heartbreaking,*" or using feminine-coded descriptors for the victim, such as "*beautiful Angel*". Outcomes of these crimes are often described by the females as "*saddening,*" while the criminal acts and resulting sentences are repeatedly labeled as "*awful*" or "*sick*". Male discourse, conversely, avoids these empty adjectives. Instead, they tend to favor a more referential and classificatory lexical style. These speakers use analytical terms like "*parasocial attachments,*" "*psychopaths,*" or "*sociopath*". This indicates a linguistic priority for categorization and classification over emotional stance-taking.

Furthermore, the data shows female users prioritizing social harmony and interpersonal sensitivity through hyper-politeness, which Lakoff associates with a non-dominant social position. This is evident in the use of formal blessings like "*Rest in peace*" and the offering of "*deepest*" or "*heartfelt*" condolences. Polite expressions of respect, such as saluting those who expose crimes, also align with this orientation toward relational maintenance. Male commenters typically bypass these politeness strategies in favor of direct moral condemnation. They frequently argue that criminals "*deserve the death penalty*," "*should be under the jail*," or "*must rot under the weight of a punishment*," prioritizing judgment. However, occasional mitigated forms such as "*Please take it seriously...*" indicate that politeness is not entirely absent from the male dataset.

Lakoff (1975) further identifies intensifiers, emphatic punctuation (talking in italics) and WH-imperatives as strategies used in female discourse to express emotional intensity and seek consensus. In the female dataset, intensifiers such as "*so much*" and "*too many*" are used to emphasize the scale of violence. This is further reinforced with extreme punctuation and capitalization like in "IF ONLY POLICE DID BETTER TO PROTECT VICTIMS OF STALKING AND CYBER CRIMES!!!!" where the capitalization and repeated exclamation marks function to heighten the emotional intensity. However, these features are not solely exclusive to female commenters. In the male dataset, users employ similar intensifiers, such as "*so/really/very sad*" "*highly condemned*" and "*absolutely disgusting*," and also exaggerated prosodic punctuation such as "What's with these sentences?!!!" or "Only one year..???" and "severe punishment than this...!!!". This indicates that males also rely on intensifiers and exaggerated punctuation to convey heightened emotions and reactions.

A similar pattern is observed in the use of WH-imperatives. While Lakoff (1975) identifies the WH-imperative as a strategy for softening commands, the female commenters in this dataset utilize WH-interrogatives, such as asking

“How many more women have to lose their lives?”, not as mitigated requests, but as rhetorical tools to construct emotional rapport. These interrogatives serve to invite agreement with the speaker’s moral stance rather than asserting a direct claim. In contrast, male commenters rarely employ interrogatives for stance-taking, favoring instead the unmitigated imperatives.

4.3 Application of Tannen’s (1990) Difference Model

The application of Deborah Tannen’s (1990) Difference Model to the data shows a clear split between “report-talk,” used mostly by men to maintain status, and “rapport-talk,” used by women to build connection. This is clearly visible in the comments across her six key contrasts.

In the dataset, the male comments usually focus on status to establish authority and hierarchy, while the female comments prioritize support. Male discourse is characterized by authoritative judgments, such as labeling donors as *“insane people”* and asserting that the perpetrator *“must rot in jail”*. Conversely, female discourse is centered on support. This is seen in the way they focus on building relational connection to victims and their families, using *“my heartfelt condolences”* and blessings like *“beautiful Angel”* to offer comfort and support.

A further contrast appears in communicative intent, where males tend to offer advice while females emphasize understanding. Male discourse frequently acts as a problem-solving mechanism, providing direct guidance such as *“take it seriously”* or *“contact your local station,”* which naturally puts the male speaker in a position of authority. Female discourse, however, prioritizes emotional validation and understanding. They focus on understanding the victim’s perspective and explaining the emotional reality of women’s reactions to violence such as in *“That poor girl. I can’t even imagine how awful it must have been...”*.

Male discourse in the dataset is also heavily information-oriented, which aligns with Tannen’s concept of report-talk. These speakers focus on explanatory

frameworks, including stalker psychology and parasocial attachment patterns as mentioned by Kangmin. In contrast, female discourse is feelings-oriented, with emotional language dominating. The use of adjectives such as “*saddening*,” alongside expressions of frustration, anger, and admiration, evaluate the situation emotionally rather than simply reporting the facts of the crime.

In addition, the comments reveal a preference for orders among male participants and proposals among female participants. Male commenters frequently employ direct imperatives and an intensified directive tone, such as “*must...*” or “*should be...*” Female participants, by contrast, utilize indirect questioning and rhetorical inquiries. Rhetorical questions such as “*When will there be prevention...?*” functions as an implicit call for reflection.

In line with Tannen’s framework, the data also reflects a contrast between conflict and compromise. Male discourse in the comments often takes a blunt and confrontational tone, as seen in the way they use strong moral judgments and direct condemnation of people or institutions like in Joseph’s comment “*it would be a stain in the face of criminal justice...*”. Female discourse, on the other hand, leans more toward a “social harmony” orientation. Though not frequently used, instead of making a direct attack, the female commenters often balance their criticism with empathy or ask questions that invite everyone to reflect together, like in Morgan’s comment “*My heartfelt condolences to this woman’s family...when will men stop abusing and killing women...the criminal justice and civil justice system is not meeting the needs of women facing domestic abuse...*”.

Finally, independence, as described by Tannen, is not clearly observed in the male data. Instead, the language is characterized by assertiveness and directive control. Female participants, in contrast, orient toward intimacy by seeking emotional identification with the victim. This is demonstrated through expressions such as “*I can’t even imagine how awful it must be...*” which bridges the gap between the observer and the victim through shared vulnerability.

While the data generally aligns with Tannen’s contrasts, the online discourse shows a hybrid communication style. For example, the use of academic terminology like "*nuances of coercive control*" or direct systemic critiques demonstrates that rapport-talk can integrate report-talk elements to strengthen advocacy. This shows that in modern online talks about violence, people don't always stick to "typical" male or female speech. Instead, they mix different styles to show how complicated and serious the topic is.

4.4 Application of Morphological Features

The morphological analysis of the dataset focuses on the internal structure of words to uncover how linguistic building blocks reflect gendered social dynamics in digital discourse. Morphology offers a granular view of how users convey their perspectives. In the following section, the data is categorized to show how morphological choices serve specific functions.

4.4.1 Compounding

Table 1: Compounding in Digital Discourse

<i>Morphological Feature</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Compounding</i>	“Death Penalty”, “Sociopath”, “Psychopaths”	“Heartbreaking”, “Lawmakers”, “Domestic Abuse”, “Cybercrimes”, “Criminal Justice”

The data is categorized as shown in Table 1, and it is evident that males employ noun-noun compounds such as “*Sociopath*” and “*death penalty*” to create clinical or legal labels that categorize the offender, establishing the “report-talk”

distance from the trauma. In contrast, females employ evaluative and systemic compounds like “*heartbreaking*”, “*lawmakers*”, and “*criminal justice*” to create a connection between emotional solidarity and institutional critique.

4.4.2 Tense Marking

Table 2: Tense Marking in Digital Discourse

<i>Morphological Feature</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Tense Marking</i>	“It <i>was</i> really sad...”	“Male entitlement <i>kills</i> women.” “...poor women <i>had</i> to endure.” “...women <i>are deciding</i> not to have...”

In Table 2, the discrepancy in tense marking reveals how male and female participants utilize different grammatical timeframes to perform their social roles in digital discourse.

In the male dataset, the reliance on the simple present and past tenses reflects an approach rooted in discursive dominance and report-talk, as though they are closing the discussion. In contrast, the female dataset utilizes the present tense mainly to highlight the persistent nature of systemic violence. By focusing on the ongoing tragedy rather than a static conclusion, female participants prioritize rapport-talk and emotional identification using the internal structure of verbs to emphasize the victims’ tragic experiences.

4.4.3 Clipping

Table 3: Clipping in Digital Discourse

<i>Morphological Feature</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Clipping</i>	“if someone randomly starts acting <i>sus</i> ...”	“A <i>perv</i> like him deserves to suffer.”

Table 3 reveals the instances of clipping used by both genders.

In the male dataset, the use of clipped words like “*sus*” (originally suspicious) reflects the discursive dominance approach that males tend to utilize. By stripping away syllables of observation, male participants reveal their judgement as if it is common sense and delivering directives to create a sense of finality. Conversely, the female dataset utilizes clipping by using the term “*perv*” (originally pervert). By clipping the word into a more aggressive sounding and punchy form, it amplifies the emotional weight of their condemnation.

4.4.4 Blending

Table 4: Blending in Digital Discourse

<i>Morphological Feature</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Blending</i>	“I don't care what the <i>netizens</i> are saying to defend him...”	“Another case of <i>femicide</i> ignored...”

Table 4 demonstrates limited instances of blending.

In the male dataset, a comment written by user Joseph G.R employs the blend “*netizens*” derived from *internet* + *citizen* where online users are conceptualized as members of an online community. This blend situates the discussion within a collective digital space and allows the speaker to comment on the opinions and behaviors of others while maintaining his distance as an observer. By doing so, it reflects the tendency toward structuring discourse around categories and groups, aligning with a more report-talk oriented style of communication. Moving on, the use of the blend “*femicide*” derived from *female* + *homicide* in a comment on Instagram by user Ann Marie reflect a clear socio-political framing of the act. By merging the victim’s identity with the crime, the speaker lexicalizes a broader pattern of systemic violence rather than an isolated system. Moreover, this choice demonstrates an analytical and more engaged

approach which aligns with rapport-talk to build a shared understanding of social inequalities.

4.4.5 Conversion

Table 5: Conversion in Digital Discourse

<i>Morphological Feature</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Conversion</i>	“... don’t <i>friend</i> people who....<i>stop</i> and <i>block</i> them...” “<i>Block</i> them..., ” “<i>Police</i> your own safety...”	-

Table 5 illustrates how conversion is utilized to assert specific social roles and to streamline digital interaction.

In the male dataset, the use of converted terms such as “*friend*,” “*stop*,” and “*block*,” by user Zack and “*Police*” by user Lee Kangmin reflects an approach rooted in dominance. By changing nouns associated with control and authority into imperative verbs, the male participants deliver directives which aim for behavioral regulation which prioritizes status over emotional connection. However, in the female dataset, no instances of conversion are present.

4.4.6 Derivation

Table 6: Derivation in Digital Discourse

<i>Morphological Feature</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Derivation</i>	“<i>Stalker</i>,” “<i>Murderer</i>,” “<i>Sociopathic</i>,”	““<i>Lawmaker</i>,” “<i>Prevention</i>,” “<i>Entitlement</i>,”

	“Deranged,”	““Heartbreaking”
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Table 6 above demonstrates the distinction in how males and females employ derivation in digital discourse, and the way these words are formed demonstrates a major difference in how males and females approach the topic of gender-based violence.

Males used derivation as a form to diagnose and judge. Since they are creating sharp and descriptive labels such as “*sociopathic*,” and “*deranged*,” they take on a judge-like persona that looks at the criminal from a distance. This is a typical Dominance move as they seek to establish authority. On the other hand, females employ derivation to advocate and analyze the situation. By turning actions into big ideas like “*prevention*,” they shift the focus more on the actual problem of a broken system which continuously fails to protect women, and away from the individual criminal. Furthermore, terms such as “entitlement,” and “heartbreaking” reveal the affective depth of their discourse which emphasizes emotional engagement along with critical analysis.

4.5 Application of Syntactic Features

The transition from morphological to syntactic analysis facilitates a shift from examining individual words and lexical units to investigating how sentence structures encode specific characteristics in online discourse.

In the following section, the data is categorized to illustrate how syntactic structures serve certain communicative and ideological functions.

4.5.1 Epistemic Modality

Table 7 : Epistemic Modality in Online Discourse

<i>Function</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Certainty</i>	“this is unfortunately only <i>going to</i> happen more often”	“I’m <i>sure</i> there are people” “ <i>inevitably</i> the outcome is...” “... <i>will</i> do it all over again”
<i>Probability</i>	“it will <i>probably</i> keep happening.”	“I <i>don’t think</i> it’s about the money...” “I’m <i>not sure</i> ...”
<i>Possibility</i>	“I know it <i>might</i> sound insane...” “... <i>could</i> it ever be prevented?”	“I <i>can’t</i> even imagine...” “How is it <i>possible</i> ...?” “I <i>wouldn’t</i> trust anybody...”

Table 7 illustrates that epistemic modality focuses on the syntactic realization of the participants’ degrees of certainty, probability, and possibility.

In instances of certainty, the male dataset utilizes predictive truth-claims like “this is unfortunately *only going to happen more*”, a comment written by Mike. When the discourse shifts towards probability, markers suggest logical conclusions based on observation. Male users like Jamie utilize “it will *probably* keep happening” in their comments to maintain analytical distance. Finally, the syntax of possibility uses markers to explore ambiguous areas of intent. Speculative hedging such as “*might*” in Zack’s comment “I know it *might* sound insane...” enables speakers to introduce judgements while also reducing their commitment to the proposition. Aatika’s comment on an Instagram post “...*could* it ever be prevented?” redirects the attention to the structural and systemic complexity of violence. Having said that, in the female dataset, instances of certainty utilize marker to project inevitable social and judicial outcomes. Mira’s assertion “I’m *sure* there are people...” and Morgan’s observation “*inevitably* the

outcome is...” both employ certainty to establish facts. Similarly, Andrea’s comment regarding an offender who “*will* do it all over again” frames recurring violence as a certain and predetermined reality. When the discourse moves to probability, markers indicate interpretation. Female users employ clauses like “I *don’t think...*” and hedges like “I’m *not sure...*” to frame statements as subjective. Finally, the syntax of possibility addresses the gray area of systemic prevention and the limits of human knowledge. Interrogative structures such as “How is it *possible...*?” focus on active inquiry.

4.5.2 Deontic Modality

Table 8 : Deontic Modality in Online Discourse

<i>Function</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Necessity</i> (<i>Strong Obligation</i>)	"...the murderer <i>must</i> rot under the weight of a punishment..."	"How many more women <i>have to</i> lose their lives?"
<i>Advisability</i> (<i>Recommendation</i>)	"This is why I often <i>advise</i> women against..." "Sounds like that’s a country that <i>should</i> be avoided."	"The judge... <i>should</i> be charged with the same crime." "...he and everyone involved <i>should</i> get a life sentence."
<i>Possibility</i> (<i>Permission</i>)	-	"...men... who believe they <i>can</i> do whatever they want to women..."

Deontic modality examines how users syntactically express varying levels of necessity, advisability, and possibility as shown in Table 8.

Among the male commenters, strong obligation is often used to inflict strict social rules or demand harsh retributions. For instance, Ali Mutlu uses the modal “must” to stress the moral and legal imperative that the murderer “*must* rot under the weight of punishment...” Regarding advisability, male users tend to position themselves as a detached observer offering guidelines and advice. User Kangmin

uses the lexical verb “*advise*” to warn women about the dangers of social media presence, while user Gilberto uses the modal “*should*” to suggest avoiding a country entirely. There are no instances of possibility in the male dataset.

In contrast, female commenters use necessity markers like “*have to*” to emphasize systemic failures and the tragic experience of the victims. This is demonstrated in Ann Marie’s comment “how many more women *have to* lose their lives?” When expressing advisability, females employ “*should*” to demand accountability from institutions, like in “The judge... *should* be charged with the same crime” and in “...he and everyone involved *should* get a life sentence.” Lastly, possibility is utilized to criticize toxic entitlement. User Ann Marie underscores this by pointing out the dangerous assumption of violent men who “...believe they *can* do whatever they want to women.

4.5.3 Grammatical Mood

Table 9: Grammatical Mood in Digital Discourse

<i>Mood</i>	<i>Male Examples</i>	<i>Female Examples</i>
<i>Indicative</i>	“As the lines blur between... this is unfortunately only going to happen more often...” “...the victims at the end are the ones being shamed...”	“Male entitlement kills women” “She survived the w@r [war] in Ukraine, but not the violence in the US”
<i>Imperative</i>	“...stop and block them” “Be safe and proactive!” “Police your own safety. Block them, tell someone, and contact...”	-
<i>Subjunctive</i>	“May she rest in peace, and may her family find healing.”	“I wish there was more coverage...” “I wish I was a judge in South Korea...”

<i>Interrogative</i>	"What's with these sentences?!" "he'll be out in 20 years?!" "Where are those VIPs that should be behind bars..."	"How many more women have to lose their lives?" "When will there be prevention to stop this ...?" "How is it possible...?"
<i>Conditional</i>	"It would be a stain in...if the culprit does not get the punishment." "if someone randomly starts acting sus..."	"I wouldn't trust anybody with myself or my children if this was the sentence..."

Table 9 illustrates distinct patterns in how male and female commenters utilize grammatical moods to showcase their communicative intent.

In the male dataset, there is a prominent reliance on the imperative mood to issue directives and prompt immediate action. Commenters like Zack and Kangmin use the imperative mood to instruct women to "...*stop* and *block* them" and to "*Police* your own safety. *Block* them, *tell* someone, and *contact*..." which also frames safety as a matter of personal responsibility. Additionally, the indicative mood is used to present statements and assertions, as seen in commenter Mike's assertion that violence is "*unfortunately only going to happen more often*." The male use of the interrogative mood appears to take a form of rhetorical outrage, as evident in commenter James's exclamation "*he'll be out in 20 years?!*" Additionally, male commenters apply conditional mood to frame conditional advice "*if someone randomly starts acting sus...*" or to outline conditional consequences for the justice system "*It would be a stain... if the culprit does not get the punishment*". Finally, the subjunctive mood is used to offer prayer and condolences like in "*May she rest in peace...*" Conversely, the female dataset utilizes a variety of moods to interrogate systemic failures and express a desire for structural change. While the indicative mood is used for powerful truth-claims like Caitlyn's "*Male entitlement kills women*," it is frequently balanced by the interrogative mood to challenge the status quo rather

than seek simple information. This is exemplified by Ann Marie's question, "*How many more women have to lose their lives?*". Furthermore, female participants employ the subjunctive mood to convey hypothetical desires for a better justice system, such as Vicky's wish, "*I wish I was a judge in South Korea...*" and Minjung's hope for "*more coverage*". The use of the conditional mood, as seen in Julia's statement that she "*wouldn't trust anybody*" if low sentences continue, underscores a collective concern with the moral consequences of institutional failure.

4.5.4 Finite and Non-finite Clauses

Table 10: Functions of Finite and Non-Finite Clauses in Digital Discourse

	<i>Finite Clauses</i>	<i>Non-Finite Clauses</i>
<i>Male Comments</i>	"Everything he did to her...He must rot in jail." "...nobody helped her. No one was willing..."	"...to restrict them but..." "...trying to friend these weirdos...." "...believing they're owed ..."
<i>Female Comments</i>	"she didn't deserve this" "Lawmakers do not protect women" "one woman....will experience....will be murdered..."	"to face..." "to be abused or murdered" "to eradicate"

Table 10 provides the distribution of clause types to demonstrate how gender-based violence is framed in online discourse.

In the male dataset, finite clauses represent anchored narratives which focus on judgements and observations. For instance, "*nobody helped her... no one was willing....*" presents violence as something simply being reported or observed rather than personally evaluated. Even in the comment written by James "*Everything he did to her and he'll be out in 20 years?! He must rot in jail*" the focus is on the legal consequences and outcomes rather than an emotional

reaction. So, male finite clauses tend to focus on reporting events, explaining behavior, and commenting on systems. However, in the female comments, finite clauses are more often used to express opinions and shed a light on responsibility. For example, Caitlyn’s comment “*Male entitlement kills women*” and Andrea’s comment “*Lawmakers do not protect women...*” directly criticize social institutions. Moreover, the clause “*one woman....will experience....will be murdered...*” showcases violence as an ongoing reality and heightens the sense of urgency and severity of the matter. This demonstrates that female finite clauses are more evaluative and focused on the injustice and accountability.

Moving on, non-finite clauses show a similar difference. In the male dataset, phrases like “*trying to friend these weirdos...*” and “*...believing they’re owed something...*” describe behavior in a broader and detached way. The phrase “*....not to restrict them but...*” also shows a more cautious, explanatory and authoritative tone that males tend to utilize to position themselves as rational advisors. On the other hand, the non-finite clauses in the female dataset focus more on harm and protection. To elaborate, the phrases in Mona and Morgan’s comments, respectively, “*...to face violence*” and “*..to be abused or murdered...*” highlight the experience of the victims, and “*...to eradicate them...*” shows a stronger call for action.

4.5.5 Agent and Patient Roles

Table 11: Agent and Patient roles in the Male Dataset

<i>Agent</i>	<i>Action</i>	<i>Patient</i>
Criminals	Violated	Them (the victims)
No one	was willing to protect/ help	Innocent girl
Murderer	must rot	-
Deranged being	Took away	A chance at new life (the woman)

Society	Shames	Victims (the women)
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Agent-patient analysis focuses on how the participants are syntactically positioned as the doers of the action or the recipient of the action.

Table 11 reveals how in the male comments agents are often present but in a generalized and abstracted manner. Agents such as “*criminals*,” “*no one*” and “*deranged being*” clearly illustrate how the responsibility is made less specific and diffused. Even when a clear agent such as “*murderer*” appears, the emphasis is on the doer’s outcome (must rot) rather than on the action of murdering itself. In contrast, the patients are consistently clear and concrete, which creates a pattern where the victims are easily identified, while the agency is softened and generalized.

Table 12: Agent and Patient Roles in the Female Dataset

<i>Agent</i>	<i>Action</i>	<i>Patient</i>
Male entitlement	Kills	women
Men	Abusing and killing	women
Lawmakers	Do not protect/ endanger	women
Men	Eradicate	Them (women)
Partner/ ex partner	Murder and abuse	women

Table 12 showcase the female dataset where both agents and patient are more explicitly defined. Agents such as “*male entitlement*,” “*men*,” “*lawmakers*” and “*partner/ ex partner*” are clearly identified and directly linked to the harmful actions. Moreover, the patients are heavily centered on the victims and clearly emphasized on the gender of the victim as well. Unlike the male dataset, these constructions make it clear about who is responsible. The data suggests that male comments tend to present clearly identifiable victims alongside more generalized

agents, whereas the female comments construct both agents and actions explicitly to assign the responsibility to specific individuals or social constructions.

4.5.6 Sentence Ambiguity

Sentence ambiguity occurs when the structure, syntactic or referential, allows for more than one possible interpretation. In the male dataset, ambiguity is sometimes used to avoid specifying responsibility through vague responsibility. For example, in Sayed's comment on an Instagram post "*nobody helped her...no one was willing...*" the referent "no one" is unclear and can be interpreted as either the bystanders, the institutions, or the society as a whole/ This lack of specificity shifts focus away from individual agents and toward a general failure which gives a report-like tone. In contrast, the female dataset uses ambiguity to broaden critique, rather than avoid responsibility. For instance, in "*Male entitlement kills women,*" the phrase "male entitlement" can refer both to an individual mindset and also a wider social issue. Moreover, ambiguity appears in the use of the pronoun "it" for example in "*the trauma that her family and friends must be experiencing... It's heartbreaking.*" Here, it functions as a broad reference as it may refer to the trauma the family is experiencing, or the violent nature of the crime itself.

4.5.7 Main and Subordinate Clauses

The syntactic organization of sentences further reveals a clear divide in how information is prioritized through the use of main and subordinate clauses. To begin with, in the male dataset, subordinate clauses are frequently used for contextual clauses which focus more on the logic, time and conditions. Male commenters tend to use extra clauses as a means to set up the conditions and rules of situations, such as Zack who comments "*If someone randomly starts acting sus and.....stop and block them,*" and Bilal's comment "*It would be a stain in the face of the criminal justice system if the culprit does not get the punishment*" to

set up a logical premise. Additionally, Kangmin explains the timing of the perpetrator's anger in "...*when those expectations aren't met, they spiral into backlash*," and Mike uses a temporal adverbial clause to explain the why and when these crimes occur in "*As the lines blur between the internet and reality, this is unfortunately only going to happen more often*," which allows him to step back and comment on the mechanics of the situation rather than the individuals involved. Conversely, in the female dataset, subordinate clauses are frequently used as relative (adjective) clauses which focus more on modifying and further specifying referents. Female commenters tend to use extra clauses as a means to elaborate on the identity and characteristics of the people involved, such as Ann Marie who comments, "There are too many men at liberty *who believe they can do whatever they want to women, who hate women so much they have to eradicate them*", and Emma's comment, "The judge *who released him* should be...", to restrict and identify a specific individual. Additionally, Andrea emphasizes the perpetrator's specific actions in "How is it possible that a man *that ruined multiple women's lives* just gets 1 year?", which allows them to elaborate on the participants within the clause and keep the focus squarely on the identity.

4.5.8 Case and Gender

Within clause structures, case highlights how participants are syntactically positioned within the sentence in relation to the verb. Case is primarily realized in pronoun forms which mark whether a participant functions as the subject (nominative), object (objective), or shows possession (possessive) in the clause. In the male dataset, the nominative form frequently appears in both implicit and explicit subject positions. Commenters frequently show agency through imperative clause structures where the subject is an implied second person "you," and the grammatical focus shifts to the commanded action. For instance, Kangmin's comment, "...[You] *Police your own safety*...", Zack's "...[You] *stop and block them*..." and additionally Mathew's "[You] *Stop trying to friend*..." all

unveil the addressee as the subject of the action.”. This pattern is observed in a substantial proportion of the male dataset, which reveals how males frequently shift the responsibility from the perpetrator to the receiver of their command, altering how agency is reflected within the clause. Objective forms are also used to refer to the affected entity like “them” and “him”. By contrast, female commenters consistently position the perpetrators in the subject position, highlighting them as the agent of the harm. This is evident in the comment written by Julia “...*the way he destroyed their trust...he and everyone involved should...*” where the perpetrator is the subject responsible for the action. Similarly, in Ruby’s comment “*he should be made to suffer...*,” and Andrea’s comment “...*as soon as he’s out, he’ll do it all over again*” both make the offender the subject which reinforces clear attribution of agency. This tendency appears across the majority of the comments, reflecting a consistent focus on direct responsibility.

Gender reference further clarifies how the participants are linguistically classified within the dataset. In the male dataset, commenters consistently rely on gender-neutral or abstract categorical labels. Male commenters often refer to the perpetrator as “*people*,” “*the murderer*,” “*criminals*,” or “*psychopaths*.” These choices reduce explicit gender-marking, treating the act committed by a specific “type” of person, like a “criminal” rather than a behavior linked to a specific gender. Conversely, female commenters steadily employ explicit masculine references to identify the perpetrators and link violence directly to the male gender. Examples like “too many *men* at liberty,” “when will *men* stop abusing...,” “a *man* that ruined multiple women’s lives...,” and “*male* entitlement kills women...” all explicitly foreground masculinity as a source of harm, directly associating gender with responsibility.

4.5.9 Aspect, Tense and Voice

Having examined who is positioned in relation to the action, aspect turns to how that action is framed as completed, ongoing, or temporally extended through perfective, progressive and perfect constructions. The male dataset more frequently distributes aspect between progressive and perfective forms. Progressive structures such as “the point he *is making*...,” “what the netizens *are saying*...,” “...are the ones *being shamed*...” and “...starts *acting* sus...,” present actions as continuous, framing behavior as an ongoing situation. They also convey ongoing activity without specifying a clear time boundary. At the same time, perfective forms such as “*gave*,” “*violated*,” “*helped*” and “*outran*” present actions as completed events. These verbs draw the situation as a series of finished actions, focusing on what happened rather than how they develop over time. The use of both progressing and perfective forms by the male commenters allows them to shift between describing ongoing behavior and reporting completed events.

On the other hand, aspect in the female dataset mainly appears as perfective constructions that present actions as completed and consequential. Verbs like “*destroyed*,” “*ruined*,” “*released*,” and “*deserved*” frame violence as finished events with clear outcomes which also emphasize the impact of the harm. Using perfective aspect keeps the focus on what has already been done and the lasting effects of those actions. Simultaneously, progressive forms such as “*is not meeting*,” “*are deciding*” and “*are not trying*” are used to present these events as ongoing social conditions. These constructions showcase the issue as continuous and not isolated, suggesting that these problems persist in society and not as individual cases. Overall, the female commenters’ combination of perfective and progressive aspects highlights both the completed nature of the violence, as well as their ongoing relevance in society, resulting in a more consequence-focused framing of events.

The tense in both sets of data reflects how each gender frames gender-based violence in relation to time. In the male dataset, they frequently rely on the simple present tense to describe recurring or habitual behavior, as seen in the statements “...people like this form unhealthy parasocial attachments...,” and “some people expect you to treat them differently...,” where actions are presented as typical and not tied to a certain event. When referring to incidents that have already occurred, the future tense is used by male commenters to describe the violence as inevitable ongoing trends, like in “this is going to happen more often...” and “it will probably keep happening...”

In contrast, female commenters employ all three tenses to connect the specific events to larger systemic conditions. For example, past tense was utilized to emphasize the impact and finality of the violence like in “she survived the war in... but not the violence in...,” “he destroyed their trust,” and “a man ruined multiple women’s lives...” At the same time, the present tense showcases these issues as ongoing realities as seen in the statements “male entitlement kills women,” and “lawmakers do not protect women...” Finally, the future tense projects these violent patterns forward which highlights the continuity of the issue, as in “one in four women will experience domestic abuse...”

Voice in the dataset reflects how responsibility is either explicitly assigned to the agents or backgrounded through syntactic structure. Beginning with the male dataset, the active voice is predominantly used as active imperatives Zack’s instruction “stop and block them...,” and Kangmin’s advice “police your own safety...” However, when the focus shifts to systemic failure, male commenters adopt the passive voice to critique the society and institutions. For instance, Dexter incorporates passive voice to highlight how victims are shamed by society in his comment “...the victims at the end are the ones *being shamed*,” and Gilberto employs the passive to question institutional power in his statement “the police *were forced to investigate*...” Conversely, female commenters rely heavily

on the active voice to emphasize the agent of the harm remains the as the main focus of the sentence. By placing the actor in the subject position, as in Ann Marie's description of men "who *believe* they *can do* whatever they *want* to women..." and Jullia's observation "...the way *he destroyed* their trust...", the syntax reveals direct accountability for the actions performed. While the active voice is the dominant structure, female commenters also use the passive voice to emphasize the irreversible impact on victims. The use of a be-passive with an explicit by-phrase, as stated by Morgan in "one woman...*will be murdered by her partner or ex partner*" and Pauline's description of a life that "*is ended in such a brutal way...*" both place the emphasis on the victim as the one affected.

4.6 Results and Findings of the Analysis

The following section presents the results and findings of the linguistic analysis of the sets of data according to Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model, Tannen's (1990) Difference Model, and syntactic and morphological features identified in the data.

4.6.1 Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model

The distribution of linguistic features associated with Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model was identified and quantified across both datasets, as presented in Figure 1. A total of 24 occurrences were recorded in the female dataset, compared to 12 occurrences in the male dataset. The most frequent feature in the female dataset was "Empty Adjectives," with a total of 10 occurrences found in the comments, and no occurrence of this feature was identified in the male dataset. "Hedges, mitigators and modal expressions" were recorded 5 times in the female comments, and 2 times in the male comments. "Intensifiers" occurred more frequently in the male dataset with a total of 5 occurrences, while they were only found a total of 2 times in the female dataset. Similarly, "Emphatic Punctuation

(talking in italics)” was identified 4 times in the male comments, and 3 times in the female comments. Finally, “Hyper-Politeness” appeared in both datasets but found more frequent in the female comments in 4 occurrences, whereas it appeared only 1 time in the male comments.

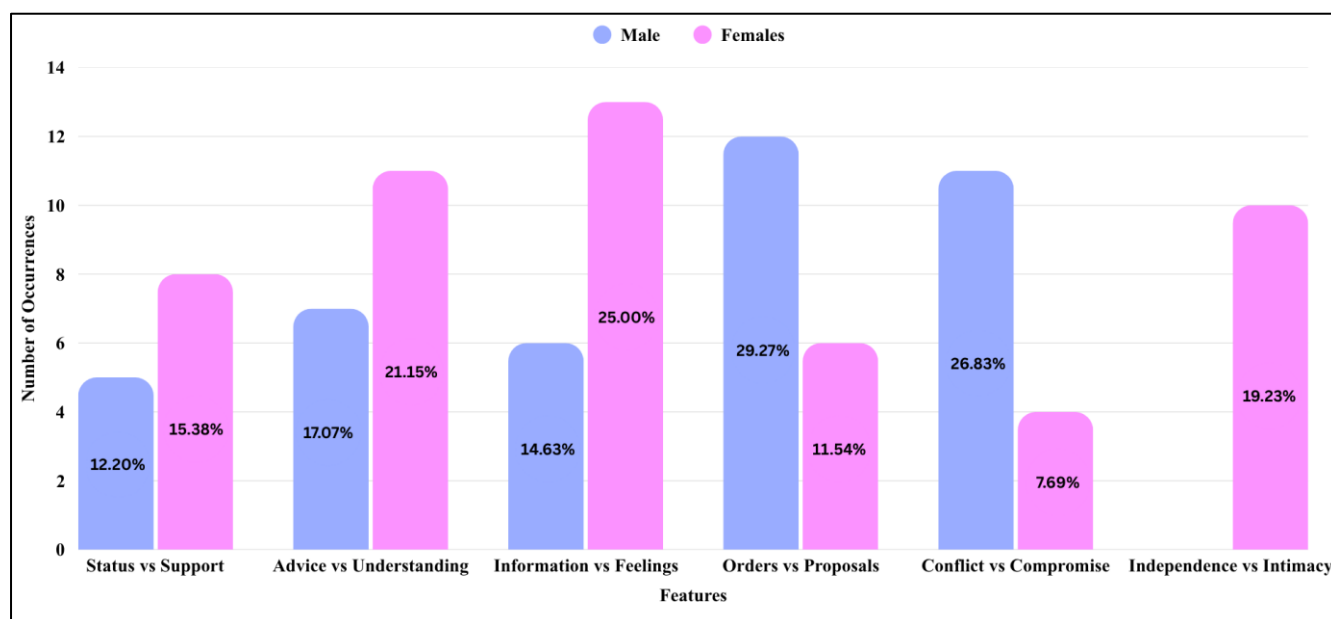
Table 13: Frequency of Lakoff’s Deficit Features by Gender

<i>Feature</i>	<i>Female Frequency</i>	<i>Male Frequency</i>
<i>Empty Adjectives</i>	41.7%	0.0%
<i>Hedges, Mitigators & Modals</i>	20.8%	16.7%
<i>Intensifiers</i>	8.3%	41.7%
<i>Talking in Italics (Punctuation)</i>	12.5%	33.3%
<i>Hyper-Politeness</i>	16.7%	8.3%
<i>Total</i>	<i>100%</i>	<i>100%</i>

4.6.2 Findings: Tannen’s (1990) Difference Model

The distribution of linguistic features related to Tannen’s (1990) Difference Model were identified across both sets of data as presented in Figure 1. A total of 41 occurrences has been identified in the males’ comments, with the most frequent feature being “Orders” as it has occurred 12 times. This is followed by “Conflict”, appearing 11 times in the male dataset. “Advice” was recorded 7 times, “Information” 6 times, and “Status” 5 times. No clear instances of independence have been recorded. In the female set of data, the total number of occurrences is 52, with the most frequently occurring feature being “Feelings” with a total of 13 appearances, closely followed by “Understanding” and “Intimacy” with 11 and 10 appearances respectively. Next is “Support” with 8 appearances, then “Proposal” with 6 occurrences, and finally “Compromise” with 4 appearances.

Figure 1. Distribution of Tannen's (1990) Difference Model Features in the Sets of Data



4.6.3 Morphological Features

Various morphological features were identified and quantified across both sets of data as presented in Table 14. A total of 85 instances has been recorded from both sets of data. In the male dataset, a total of 42 occurrences were recorded with Tense Marking emerging as the most prevalent feature at 16 instances (38.1%). This was followed by Derivation, which appeared 12 times (28.6%) and Compounding at 8 instances (19.0%). Notably, Conversion was identified 4 times (9.5%), while Clipping and Blending were the least frequent, each appearing only once (2.4% each). Finally, no instances of Invention, Acronymy, and Back-Formation have been found.

In the female dataset, a total of 43 occurrences were recorded, with Tense Marking also being the most prominent feature, occurring 19 times (44.2%). This was followed by Compounding and Derivation, where both were identified 11 times each (25.6% each). Clipping and Blending appeared minimally, only once each (2.3% each). Finally, no instances of Invention, Acronymy, and Back-

Formation have been found, and unlike the male dataset, no instance of Conversion was identified.

Table 14: Morphological Features Frequency Table

<i>Feature</i>	<i>Males</i>		<i>Females</i>	
	<i>Occurrence</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Occurrence</i>	<i>Frequency</i>
<i>Compounding</i>	8	19.0%	11	25.6%
<i>Invention</i>	0	0.0%	0	0.0%
<i>Tense Marking</i>	16	38.1%	19	44.2%
<i>Clipping</i>	1	2.4%	1	2.3%
<i>Blending</i>	1	2.4%	1	2.3%
<i>Conversion</i>	4	9.5%	0	0.0%
<i>Derivation</i>	12	28.6%	11	25.6%
<i>Acronymy</i>	0	0.0%	0	0.0%
<i>Back-formation</i>	0	0.0%	0	0.0%
<i>Total</i>	<i>42</i>	<i>100%</i>	<i>43</i>	<i>100%</i>

4.6.4 Syntactic Features

The syntactic analysis of the data reveals several distinct patterns between the linguistic choices made by each gender. Table 15 showcases all significant syntactic features and their occurrences across both male and female sets of data.

Regarding Modality, both genders showed a relatively even distribution with males being slightly higher by favoring Deontic Modality, used 6 times (54.55%), over Epistemic (45.45%) while females were found to equally employ both Epistemic and Deontic (50.00% each).

Significant variation was observed in the category of Mood. Indicative mood was the most frequently employed across both genders, 19 times (52.77%)

by the males, and 20 times (64.52%) by the females. Males utilized the Imperative mood 8 times (22.22%) in contrast to the females who have not employed it at all. Females utilized the Interrogative 6 times (19.35%) and Subjunctive 3 times (9.68%), and the Conditional 2 times (6.45%), whereas the males used the Interrogative 3 times (8.33%) and Subjunctive only 2 times (5.55%), and the Conditional 4 times (11.11%).

In terms of Finite and Non-Finite Clauses, both genders relied heavily on Finite structures. It was recorded 58 times (82.86%) in the male dataset, and 55 times (84.62%) in the female dataset. Non-Finite clauses appeared 12 times (17.14%) in the male comments, and 10 times (15.38%) in the female comments.

A sharp contrast appears in the Agent and Patient roles. In the male dataset, agents are more present with 24 instances recorded (60%) and patients recorded 16 times (40%), whereas the patients were more dominant in the female dataset, recorded 23 times (67.65%) and the agents only recorded 11 times (32.35%).

Sentence Ambiguity remains minimal in both sets of data, with only 1 instance recorded in the male comments, and 2 in the female comments.

Both groups showed a similar preference for Main Clauses, which was recorded 47 times (73.44%) in the male comments, and 38 times (71.70%) in the female comments. Subordinate clauses were used less frequent, appearing 17 times (26.56%) in the male comments, and 15 times (28.30%) in the female comments.

In case marking, nominative forms dominate in both datasets. In the male comments, it appeared 58 times (57.43%) and 44 times (42.38%) in the female comments. Objective case was recorded 24 times (23.76%) in the male comments, and 18 times (21.43%) in the female comments. Finally, the possessive case was recorded 19 times (18.81%) in the male comments, and 22 times (26.19%) in the female comments.

In the Gender category, males primarily used categorical and neutral labels at 11 instances (73.33%) recorded. They also used explicit gendered terms 4 times (26.67%). In contrast, females favored explicit gendered terms which were recorded 12 times (80%), and less frequently used categorical and neutral labels which were recorded 3 times (20%).

In terms of Aspect, males utilized the progressive most frequently, recorded 6 times (54.55%), followed by the perfective which was recorded 5 times (45.45%), while the perfect aspect was not used at all. However, females favored the perfective, counted 8 times (53.33%), followed by the progressive at 5 (33.33%) and lastly the perfect at 2 (13.33%).

Regarding Voice, both groups showed a high preference for the active voice, accounting for 64 (91.43) male instances, and 52 (96.30) female instances. The passive voice appeared significantly less at 6 times (8.57%) in the male comments, and 2 times (3.70%) in the female comments.

Finally, for Tense, the present tense was the most dominant for both genders, appearing 32 times (76.19%) in the male comments and 52 times (96.30%) in the female comments. This is followed by the past tense at 6 instances (14.29%) for the males and 12 instances (26.09%) for the females, and the future tense which occurred 4 times (9.52%) in the male comments and 6 times (13.04%) in the female comments.

Table 15: Syntactic Features Frequency Table

<i>Feature</i>		<i>Males</i>		<i>Females</i>	
		<i>Occurrence</i>	<i>Total</i>	<i>Occurrence</i>	<i>Total</i>
<i>Modality</i>	<i>Epistemic</i>	5	11	5	10
	<i>Deontic</i>	6		5	
<i>Mood</i>	<i>Indicative</i>	19	36	20	31

	<i>Imperative</i>	8		0	
	<i>Interrogative</i>	3		6	
	<i>Conditional</i>	4		2	
	<i>Subjunctive</i>	2		3	
Clauses	<i>Finite</i>	58	70	55	65
	<i>Non-Finite</i>	12		10	
Agent and Patient Roles	<i>Agent</i>	24	40	11	34
	<i>Patient</i>	16		23	
Sentence Ambiguity		1	1	2	2
Clauses	<i>Main Clause</i>	47	64	38	53
	<i>Subordinate Clause</i>	17		15	
Case	<i>Nominative</i>	58	101	44	84
	<i>Objective</i>	24		18	
	<i>Possessive</i>	19		22	
Gender	<i>Categorical/ Neutral Labels</i>	11	15	3	15
	<i>Explicit Gendered Terms</i>	4		12	
Aspect	<i>Perfective</i>	5	11	8	15
	<i>Progressive</i>	6		5	
	<i>Perfect</i>	0		2	
Voice	<i>Active</i>	64	70	52	54
	<i>Passive</i>	6		2	
Tense	<i>Present</i>	32	42	28	46

	<i>Past</i>	6		12	
	<i>Future</i>	4		6	

4.7 Discussion of Findings

This section interprets the findings of the analysis, focusing on the observed patterns and exploring what they reveal about language use within the sets of data.

4.7.1 Discussion of Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model

The distribution of linguistic features across the datasets reveals a relationship between gender and language, which both supports and challenges Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model.

To begin with, the most utilized feature observed in the female dataset is empty adjectives, accounting for 41.7% of total occurrences. The findings show that female comments include affective descriptors that carry emotional weight in attempt to connect with the victim and community. In contrast, no instances of empty adjectives were found in the male set of data, suggesting that males distance themselves from emotions and instead establish a more analytical and serious tone. It is also observed that females use hyper-politeness twice as much (16.7%) as males, which may suggest that women use polite forms to navigate through the sensitive topic of gender-based violence safely, while males, who only used it 8.3%, appear to bypass these polite forms in favor of direct judgement. The use of hedges, mitigators and modals appear to contribute 20.8% of the instances recorded in the female dataset, and 16.7% in the male dataset. While females appear to use them slightly more often, both genders utilize them fairly which indicates that due to the sensitive nature of the topic and both genders opt to use said features to show awareness and to avoid sounding dismissive.

Interestingly, there is a major reversal recorded in the features intensifiers and talking in italics. Going against Lakoff's (1975) Deficit framework, the male dataset displays male commenters utilizing intensifiers almost five times more than females (41.7% versus 8.3%), which flips Lakoff's theory that intensifiers show female uncertainty. In the female comments, this feature is employed to showcase and emphasize the intensity of the violence. This suggests that this feature is not solely an indicator to show emotional emphasis, but it is used to make their judgements feel more forceful. Similarly, men also lead the talking in italics category as they appear to utilize them almost twice as much as females (33.3% versus 12.5%). This implies that males use punctuation to signal outrage as well as authority, suggesting that this feature is used as a tool of dominance rather than simply a feminine trait which Lakoff (1975) interprets to compensate for a lack of direct power in speech.

4.7.2 Discussion of Tannen's (1990) Difference Model

The findings of the datasets suggest that male and female commenters approach the topic of gender-based violence with different communicative goals, aligning with Tannen's (1990) idea of distinct conversational styles.

First and foremost, the equal total of 52 occurrences in both datasets indicates a balanced level of engagement overall. The most frequent features recorded for males are orders and conflict, each contributing 29.27% and 26.83% respectively. They reveal that male commenters tend to rely heavily on commands and lean towards a more direct, assertive, and authoritative stance regarding the topic. It also allows them to appear objective and distance themselves away from the perpetrators. This implies their preference for establishing distance, hierarchy and maintaining the role of the enforcer who is focused on reporting a dominant judgement. Male commenters also show a stronger preference towards status, representing 12.20% of recorded instances,

and authoritative positioning which reveals their focus on establishing authority. Next, the male dataset reveals how males have the tendency to provide advice and offering solutions. Recorded at 17.07%, it suggests that men feel the need to provide a solution to the events to position themselves as problem solvers. Moreover, male commenters appear to be more inclined toward delivering information and reporting facts, representing 14.63% of the total occurrences. They focus on explaining the behavior of perpetrators and certain psychological frameworks as a way to display their knowledge, which clearly aligns with Tannen's (1990) concept of "report talk."

In contrast, the most recorded feature is intimacy, recorded at 19.23%, which shows a stronger preference for shared involvement and relational connection. This suggests that females prioritize connection with the victims rather than evaluating the events individually. Furthermore, female commenters prioritize support more frequently, recorded at 15.38%, implying a focus on validation, reinforcing solidarity, and providing support to the victims and affected families of the crimes. Compromise appears in the female comments at a frequency of 7.69%, implying that women prefer maintaining social harmony and reduce tension to protect the online community even when expressing strong stances regarding tragic and violent events. Additionally in the female set of data, the frequent expression of understanding, representing 21.15% of the recorded instances, reveals on the females' emphasis on interpreting the events empathetically, which suggests that women prioritize the recognition of the victim's pain over the need to give advice or critique. To add on, female commenters prioritize feelings, contributing 25.0% of total occurrences, indicating a stronger orientation toward emotional expression and building rapport through affective responses, which once again align with Tannen's (1990) concept of "rapport talk".

4.7.3 Discussion of Morphological Features

The distribution of morphological features across both sets of data reveal how word formation is employed to build discourse around gender-based violence.

Firstly, tense marking is the most occurring feature for both females (44.2%) and males (38.1%), which indicates that both genders rely heavily on temporal markers to frame the events. In the female data, the tendency to utilize the present tense highlights the focus on the enduring impact of the crimes which suggest that they tend to view them as ongoing tragedies. For the males, they utilize tense in a way to describe the event as complete to establish a more factual approach.

Compounding appears with a higher frequency in the female dataset, recorded at 25.6%, compared to the male dataset where the feature was recorded at 19.0%. This indicates a female preference for creating compounded terms and expressions like “*heartfelt*” and “*heartbreaking*” which combine both emotional intensity and descriptive clarity. In contrast, male commenters employ compounding less frequently and in a different manner, where they use it to describe the perpetrator or legal terms like “death penalty”. Here, this underscores how male commenters place the events into a systemic framework which suggests that they prioritize the rational outcome of justice over the relational experience of the crime. This effectively allows them to act as an objective observer who is judging the case.

Derivation is utilized prominently by both males (28.6%) and females (25.6%) which shows that both genders actively use derived terms throughout their discourse. Male commenters mainly use derivation to describe and categorize the perpetrators of the crimes, using terms like “*deranged*,” “*stalker*” and “*murderer*”, which further reinforces the idea that they tend to act as an

observer and a judge, a typical aspect of maintaining status. Females, however, employ derivation to build intense affective descriptions, such as in “*saddening*” and “*heartbreaking*”, and to also focus on the on the weak systems that continuously fails to protect women.

Conversion is evident only in the male dataset through the male commenters’ constant assertions, recorded at 9.5%, and entirely absent in the female set of data. Male commenters appear to manipulate word classes and change regular nouns into imperative verbs as a way to assert dominance and to imply a higher degree of authority to fit their assertive stance. The absolute absence of conversion in the female dataset may suggest a more cautious adherence of the female commenters to the established linguistic norms given the serious topic, implying that women prioritize a formal and respectful tone.

Clipping and blending appear minimally in both datasets with minimal frequencies, 2.4% each in the male set of data and 2.3% each in the female set of data. The very low frequency of these features implies a shared recognition of the gravity of the topic. Since gender-based violence is a serious and sensitive topic, commenters from both genders appeared to avoid informal word formations that may come across as disrespectful.

Finally, no instances of invention, acronymy, and back-formation have been identified. This suggests that, once again due to the gravity of the topic, both male and female commenters avoid slang and informal morphology. It could be interpreted as a lack of empathy or trivialization if employed, so a total avoidance is best given the topic.

4.7.4 Discussion of Syntactic Features

The syntactic distribution of features reveals a clear divide in how male and female commenters structure their discourse in the digital space.

First and foremost, both sets of data show identical use of epistemic and deontic modality, with the male dataset recording 11 total instances and female dataset recording 10 total instances. This indicates a shared level of moral certainty, implying that both genders feel a high degree of conviction regarding the topic. Commenters are not just sharing their opinions, but are also establishing a moral requirement for justice. Moreover, the slight difference may suggest that the gravity of the crimes and topic reinforce the commenters to present strong judgements.

Regarding mood, a total of 35 instances have been recorded in the male set of data, and 31 in the female set of data. The indicative mood is the most dominant in both sets of data, presenting 54.29% of total occurrences in the male dataset, and 64.52% in the female dataset. This symbolizes a shared reliance on stating facts, suggesting that regardless of gender, the weight of the topic makes commenters describe a reality where they present what they see as the objective truth.

Following that is the imperative mood, which is only employed in the male set of comments 8 times (22.86% of total instances) and none in the female comments. Since the imperative mood is used to give orders, the fact that males used this 8 times while women avoided it completely underscores a directive stance. Male commenters view themselves as having social authority to command and direct, reflecting a more assertive approach where the speaker acts as a moral enforcer.

Next is the interrogative mood, which was counted 3 times (8.33%) in the male comments, and 6 times (19.53%) in the female comments. As the interrogative mood is used to ask questions, it implies an inquiring approach. Males employed interrogative mood only 3 times, all as rhetorical questions, to show outrage in regard to the outcomes of sentencing. Females on the other hand

use the interrogative structure to invite other into the conversation, aiming at a collective exchange, and to also show outrage.

Conditional and subjunctive moods appear minimally in the two sets of comments. Combined, these hypothetical moods appear at a low frequency, suggesting that the speaker is simply weighing potential outcomes of justice or expressing a wish for a more just social reality.

In terms of finite and non-finite clauses, both genders rely heavily on finite clauses to reveal anchored statements. Appearing 58 times in the male comments, and 55 times in the female comments, both genders appear to make definitive statements to make sure that their statements are logical. However, they differ in what kind of information is conveyed, as the male comments appear to utilize finite clauses to report the events and provide comments on the system, and in the female comments, finite clauses appear to clearly express their opinions and critique. Non-finite clauses are also employed by both genders, though minimally compared to the finite clauses, to provide extra descriptions of the crimes.

The agent and patient roles are intertwined with the employment of gendered terms. The male commenters appear to focus on the agent with 24 instances counted, but in a generalized and less explicit way. By prioritizing the doer of the action in their sentence structures, male commenters center the discourse on the act itself and the individual responsible. However, their reliance on general categorization implies their attempts at categorical distancing to avoid putting the focus on the gender of the perpetrator and instead focus on the overall image of the crime and punishment. This further reinforces the idea of male commenters acting as an objective observer who judges the act. On the other hand, Female commenters reveal a preference for the patient role, which appeared 23 times in the comments. By putting the victim in the receiving end of the sentence, female commenters emphasize the impact of the violence which

suggests a victim-centered perspective. This allows them to highlight the victim's experience and suffering, indicating that females prioritize showing solidarity, keeping the emotional aspect as the focal point in their sentences. Moreover, female users use explicit gendered terms and intentionally name the perpetrator. This suggests that females refuse to let the crime and perpetrator be anonymized and instead utilize their syntax to show true accountability.

Following is the use of main and subordinate clauses . The distribution reveals that males use more main clauses overall, recorded at 64 occurrences, compared to females, recorded at 53 occurrences, while both genders use a similar number of subordinate clauses, 17 for males and 15 for females. This suggests that male commenters tend to construct more direct and independent statements, implying a straightforward and assertive style. In contrast, the slightly lower number of main clauses in the female set of comments may indicate that female comments integrate descriptive elements more.

Sentence ambiguity remains minimal in both datasets, with only 1 instance recorded in the male comments and 2 instances in the female comments. This low frequency indicates that both genders prioritize clarity and avoid writing ambiguous sentences due to the nature of the topic. Though it is used twice in the female comments, the difference is too small to notice any pattern.

Regarding grammatical case structures, the nominative case serves as the primary tool for both genders, with a total of 58 instances in the male comments and 44 in the female comments. This is followed by the objective case with 24 occurrences recorded in the male comments and 18 in the female comments. This denotes that both genders focus primarily on identifying the agents and actions, pointing toward the accusatory and evaluative function of the topic. and lastly the possessive case. It is worth noting that the female comments do portray a higher use of possessive forms (22 times as opposed to the males' 19 times) which

suggests a greater emphasis on identity and personal relations, implying that female discourse may frame the issue in a relational way.

The temporal perspective of the events is seen through the use of different types of aspect. Female commenters utilized the perfective aspect 8 times compared to the males who used it 5 times. This proposes the female commenters focus on the crimes as irreversible and by framing it this way, it emphasizes the tragedy as a devastating and finished reality. Male commenters showed a relatively even use between the perfective (5 times) and progressive (6 times) aspects. This denotes that male commenters are balanced between viewing the crimes as a past fact and at the same time viewing the ongoing legal and social consequences. It is worth noting that the perfect aspect was used twice in the female dataset and none in the male dataset, which reinforces the idea of male commenters are somewhat more focused on the ongoing actions as opposed to the female commenters who emphasize the outcomes and impacts.

The use of active and passive voice reveal the level of assertiveness and clarity in the discourse. Both genders strongly prefer the active voice with males using it more often with 64 instances recorded compared to 52 for the females. This captures the idea that both males and females aim to clearly identify who is responsible for the crime rather than hiding it. However, the higher frequency in male comments may suggest a more assertive and direct tone. The passive voice is rarely used by both gender with low frequencies recorded, 6 times in the male comments and 2 times in the female comments which points toward the idea that both genders avoid structures that may shift attention away from the perpetrator and weaken the seriousness of the crime.

Finally, the use of tense shows how the commenters frame the situation over time. Both groups mainly utilize the present tense to express their views, appearing 32 times in the male comments and 52 times in the female comments.

The reliance on the present tense portrays their focus on establishing universal truths. The past tense, recorded 6 times in the male comments and 12 times in the female comments, unveils female commenters' tendency to focus more on what actually happened. To elaborate, their goal is to ensure that the victim's tragedy is not lost in generalities and instead is remembered as a reality that took place. Both genders used the future tense sparingly, 4 times for the males and 6 times for the females, which suggests that the gravity of the crimes in the past and present outweigh future speculations. However, when it is used it typically signals a desire for change in social behavior and legal consequences for the perpetrator.

5. Conclusion

This research paper has applied Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model and Tannen's (1990) Difference Model to 30 comments, divided equally into 15 male and 15 female comments on four social media posts published on X (Twitter) and Instagram addressing the crimes of gender-based violence. Furthermore, it has investigated the different syntactic and morphological features used that characterize male and female discourse concerning this topic by applying morphological and syntactic features to the same data. Furthermore, the triangulation method was utilized for analysis, combining both qualitative and quantitative methods to produce credible analysis.

The overall findings reveal both similarities and differences between the male and female sets of data when it comes to linguistic analysis of online discourse. Firstly, features associated with Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model appear most frequently in the female comments, specifically features like empty adjectives, hedges, and hyper-politeness. Challenging Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model, which characterizes certain features to women discourse, the findings revealed that males also highly utilize features like intensifiers, emphatic punctuation (talking in italics) and hedges, mitigators and hedges. In Tannen's

(1990) Difference Model, both groups reveal similar frequencies overall, though males favor orders, conflict and independence and females prioritize feelings, understanding, and intimacy. Morphologically, both datasets also reveal similar distributions with tense-marking being the most dominant feature in both sets of data, followed by derivation and compounding. Other features are minimally used or absent. Syntactically, both genders appear to rely heavily on using mood, specifically the indicative mood, finite clauses, main clauses, active voice, and the present tense. Slight differences appear as male commenters tend to use imperatives more, favor agent roles and progressive aspect, whereas female commenters employ a wider range of moods and favor patient roles as well as the perfective aspect. Females also use more explicit gendered terms while males lean toward neutral labels. Overall, structural patterns are shared among both datasets but differ in the functional and stylistic choices.

This research paper has answered all the research questions previously mentioned in the introduction. Regarding the first research question, which investigates the syntactic and morphological differences characterizing the language used by men and women commenting on gender-based violence on X (Twitter) and Instagram, the findings reveal shared patterns and also clear functional differences across the gendered language use. Syntactically, a clear directive stance emerges through the use of grammatical moods. Men show a high reliance on the imperative mood (22.22%) to issue commands and call for action. Women, however, avoid the imperative mood entirely and instead favor the interrogative mood (19.35%) to prompt collective reflection over the crimes rather than asserting claims. In terms of agent and patient roles, males show a stronger preference for agent-focused constructions, where they also use more generalized terms in order to shift the focus away from the fact that the perpetrators are males. Females, on the other hand, center their sentences on the patient more in order to highlight the victim's experience. Men also utilize

subordinate clauses as a tool to showcase logic, whereas women use them to provide more description of the perpetrator's identity and the crime that has occurred. Overall, these syntactic choices all together reveal that men use language to enforce moral judgements from a distance, and women use it to seek emotional identification and demand accountability. Morphologically, men frequently utilize derivation and compounding to create labels that categorize the perpetrator, which also allows the speaker to act as an observer. Conversely, women use these features to connect emotional solidarity and critique at the same time. A notable distinction is also found in derivation, where only men utilized it to turn nouns into imperative verbs to deliver directives and assert authority.

Regarding the second research question, which examines the extent to which the identified linguistic patterns align or deviate from the gendered speech norms proposed by Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model, Tannen's (1990) Difference Model, and Zimmerman and West's (1975) Dominance Model, the findings indicate interesting results. The findings support Lakoff's claims regarding the use of affective language, as female commenters frequently employ emotional empty adjectives, hyper-politeness, and hedges and mitigators to show empathy, given the topic. However, a clear deviation appears in the male dataset, as it was observed that male commenters utilized features that Lakoff associated with female speech, such as intensifiers and emphatic punctuation, which were found more often in their comments. Moving to Tannen's (1990) Difference Model, a strong alignment appears with Tannen's "Report versus Rapport" framework. Male comments consistently prioritized status, advice, and information, and their discourse acted as a problem-solving mechanism to also show authority. Female comments, however, revealed a preference for feelings, understanding, and intimacy which showcase how the female commenters prioritized creating a connection with the victims and provide support, confirming the rapport-talk stance. Finally, Zimmerman and West's (1975) Dominance model was not

applied due to the nature of the model and the data involved. The model was originally developed to analyze spoken discourse focusing on turn-taking violations and this is simply unapplicable to social media comments since they are asynchronous and the act of interrupting another speaker is not possible.

Finally, the third research question, which examines how the written context of digital discourse impacts the validity of these traditional sociolinguistic frameworks, the findings suggest that some models are not fully applicable in online environments. Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model remains applicable, but its features are not exclusive to female commenters. Male and female commenters appear to use features that are traditionally associated with the opposite gender, such as males using intensifiers and hedging. This shows that Lakoff's framework can identify linguistic patterns but it does not account for gender exclusivity in digital discourse. Tannen's (1990) Difference Model is clearly supported by the datasets as commenters of both genders demonstrate a distinction between report-talk and rapport-talk, reflecting Tannen's concept of opposite communicative purposes. However, Zimmerman and West's (1975) Dominance Model is less applicable due to the asynchronous nature of social media comments. The nature of social media allows users to carefully build their responses which clearly reduces the spontaneity and turn-taking dynamics that are crucial to spoken discourse. All in all, the traditional models, Lakoff's (1975) Deficit Model and Tannen's (1990) Difference, remain relevant in the context of modern digital discourse, whereas the validity of Zimmerman and West's (1975) Dominance Model is limited as it does not fully consider the nature of online communication.

5.1 Recommendations for Future Research

Future research can analyze comments over several time periods, rather than just the past 2 years, to examine whether the findings and hybrid digital style identified in this research remain stable or evolve over time. By doing so,

researchers can determine whether digital platforms are changing traditional gendered norms. Another useful step would be to analyze comments written in other languages, such as Arabic, to find out whether these identified patterns remain the same in other languages.

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